Columbinus

By Stephen Karem and P.J. Paparelli

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Actor 1: *Dylan, Diversion Officer (spoken in unison)*
Actor 2: *Teacher, AP (Advanced Placement – a smart one), Prep, Jock, Eric, Diversion Officer (spoken in unison)*

INTRODUCTION

Who were Eric Harris and Dylan Klebold? Together these young men were brought to the world's attention when they laid siege to Columbine High School the morning of April 20, 1999. For months before the massacre, the two had been making plans to attack their school and the people in it. We will never know answers to all of the questions left in the wake of the tragedy but this selection is designed to explore what happened before the grim events of one of the world's worst school shootings in history. Let's go back in time to Columbine, an average high school where the first hour of the day just happens to be CREATIVE WRITING. Columbinus by Stephen Karem and P.J. Paparelli.

TEACHER: Okay, let's critique the last of the narrative assignments. I'll follow along with your essay and share my comments. You're up.

DYLAN: *(uncertain, in a low voice)* The town, even at 1:00AM, was still. . .

TEACHER: You need to speak a little louder.

DYLAN: *(a bit more confident)* The town, even at 1:00AM, was still bustling with activity as the man dressed in black walked down the empty streets.

TEACHER: Great opening.

DYLAN: The moon was barely visible, hiding under a shield of clouds, adding a chill. . .

TEACHER: . . . which added a chill. . .

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DYLAN: . . . which added a chill to the atmosphere. What was most recognized about the man was the jingling of his belt chains striking not only the two visible guns, but the large bowie knife, slung in anticipation of use.

TEACHER: Great details. Well done.

DYLAN: His face was entirely in shadow, yet I could feel his anger, cutting thru the air like a razor. He noticed my presence, but paid no attention as he kept walking toward a popular bar. The Watering Hole. He stopped and waited. "For whom?" I wondered, as I saw them step out. A group of college-preps . . . the second-largest spoke up

(The students in the class become the college-preps in the story.)

DYLAN & PREP: Nice trench coat dude. That's pretty cool.

DYLAN: The man in black said nothing but I could feel his anger growing. Other preps could be heard muttering in the background . . .

DYLAN & AP: C'mon man you wouldn't shoot us. We're in the middle of a public place.

DYLAN: Yet the comment I remember the most was uttered from the biggest of the group, obviously cocky . . . power hungry.

DYLAN & JOCK: Go ahead man! Shoot me!!! I want you to shoot me!!! Ha, ha. You won't . . .

DYLAN: It was faint at first, but grew in intensity and power as I heard the man laugh. *(Actor 2 starts laughing; under his laugh…)* For almost half a minute this laugh, spawned from the most powerful place conceivable, filled the air, and thru the entire town, the entire world . . . *(As the laugh gets unbearably intense, DYLAN pulls out his an imaginary shotgun and fires on Actor 2 who falls to the ground.)* The town was utterly still. He stopped, and gave me a look I will never forget. The man smiled, and in that instant, I understood his actions.

TEACHER: Ok. Stay up there. Now, before I accept this draft, let's open it up for discussion. Comments?

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JOCK: Are you serious? It sucks. I mean, what if I wrote a little story about cleaning up the school, taking out people like him? *(JOCK stands)* This piece of shit writes about walking around the town shooting people for no reason, and you want me to what . . . to give constructive criticism? How about "throw this maniac out, and get him some help?" Look at him. What has he done to earn anyone's respect? While he's home after school *watching* Lara Croft with his faggot-ass friends, I'll still be here, serving the school. What does he do? Nothing. So, that's what he is: nobody.

TRANSITION

All through high school, Dylan was quiet, shy and a bit of a loner. But after this public humiliation things began to change. He and his friend Eric Harris began to act out; first shoplifting, then vandalism. Ultimately the pair were arrested for stealing computers from a van . . . and the court ordered them both into a diversion program. Their collective anger began to grow, and it's difficult to understand how adults at the school, at home and in the court system were so easily duped into believing that everything was OK with these two teens.

**NOTE: TOGETHER – Actors are speaking as the collective Diversion Officer assigned to both boys' cases.*

ACTOR 1: JUVENILE DIVERSION: *Session 1 - April 14, 1998*

TOGETHER: State your name.

DYLAN: Dylan Bennett Klebold

ERIC: Eric David Harris

TOGETHER: And you attend Columbine High School?

DYLAN & ERIC: *(not in unison)* Yes.

TOGETHER: And *you've* lived in Littleton all your life?

ERIC: No, I moved from Plattsburgh, NY . . . actually I was born in Wichita, moved to Ohio, Michigan, then to Plattsburgh. We moved to Littleton when I was in 7th Grade.

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TOGETHER: Ok, Dylan, describe what happened.

DYLAN: I broke into a van. Took stuff from it. Drove away (friend's car). Cops discovered us. Admitted to the crime.

ERIC: I broke into a car and stole $1700 worth of equipment, was caught thirty minutes later.

TOGETHER: And what do you make of your punishment? Instead of jail time you'll be meeting with me. I mean, you must have some reaction to that.

DYLAN: I'm hoping I can get the best I can out of it and am optimistic about it. So far it sucks.

ERIC: *(suppressing anger)* Looking forward to it. Hopefully it will set me straight.

TOGETHER: Now, what's your relationship with the co-defendant?

DYLAN: Co-defendant? We've been friends for about 4 years. Very good friends.

ERIC: He's my best friend . . . past and current.

TOGETHER: I want you to tell me what's going on. Look on that sheet and tell me which of the following you are having problems or difficulty with . . .

DYLAN: *(looks at the sheet and checks as he reads off)* Finances and Jobs.

ERIC: Anger, anxiety, authority figures, depression, disorganized thoughts, homicidal thoughts, jealousy, loneliness, mood swings, obsessive thoughts, racing thoughts, stress, suspiciousness . . . oh, and . . . *(a final check)* . . . temper.

TOGETHER: Eric? Please, could you try and explain?

ERIC: I . . . *(Beat. A sincere, but difficult attempt to open up)* Sometimes I get angry. I punch walls.

TOGETHER: Have you ever used drugs?

DYLAN: Drugs are a waste of everything. Definitely not worth it.

ERIC: I'm on medication. Anti-depressants. I've had drinks, smoked pot, but I don't need that anymore.

ACTOR 2: **JUVENILE DIVERSION:** ***Session 2 – January 14, 1999***

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TOGETHER: So what do you think of your Diversion classes?

ERIC: The anger management class I took was helpful in many ways. If a person does not want to control his or her anger, then it can be a problem.

DYLAN: Truthfully? It wasn't worth my time. It was an eight-hour day of pointless review and cramped conditions. I feel that I shouldn't have had to take that class, but I'm just trying to get out of the diversion program.

TOGETHER: If you want to get through this process, no more excuses.

DYLAN: I'm working for my next-door neighbor doing yard work and landscaping . . .

ERIC: And I've changed my meds . . . my mood is improving and I feel better.

TOGETHER: Good. Very good.

DYLAN: Most importantly . . . *(the next two lines are spoken in unison)*

ERIC: I am truly sorry for what I have done.

DYLAN: I know what I did was wrong.

TOGETHER: I placed a call to your parents to discuss early termination, and they have no problems with my decision. *(DYLAN and ERIC smile.)*

DYLAN AS DO's VOICE: *(Reading the final diversion report)* Eric did a very nice job on Diversion. He is a very bright young man who is likely to succeed in life. Seems responsible and remorseful. He suffers from depression but has changed his meds and feels better. He impressed me as being very articulate and intelligent. *(Lights on ERIC, sitting on a table holding a video camera. This is a video journal entry.)*

ERIC: Well folks, today was a very important day. Today, I got a double barrel 12 gauge shotgun, a pump action 12 gauge shotgun, and a 9mm carbine. It's all over now, this is point of no return. *(beat)* It's weird, I don't feel like punching through a door anymore.

ACTOR 1: January 14, 1999: ERIC HARRIS: File Closed.

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ERIC AS DO's VOICE: Dylan is a bright young man who has a great deal of potential. If he is able to tap his potential and become self-motivated he should do well in life. All in all: Nice young man, kind of goofy, and a bizarre sense of humor, he makes me laugh. *(Lights on DYLAN, sitting on a table holding a video camera. This is a video journal entry.)*

DYLAN: I just got back from Arizona. Can you believe it? Touring a college with my dad. . . it was cool. But they have no clue. Days from now the judgment will begin. It's interesting knowing I'm going to die . . . everything has a touch of triviality to it.

ACTOR 2: January 14, 1999: DYLAN KLEBOLD: File Closed.

********* SCENE CHANGE *******

(DYLAN is recording ERIC. They are in his bedroom. Dylan positions the camera on a tripod or table so it can record them both. The camera should be positioned between actors and audience so action can take place facing the audience)

ERIC: Ready?

DYLAN: Ready.

ERIC: Ok, it's about 1:30AM. Less than 48 hours to Judgment Day. We want to take you on a tour of what we've been up to over the last few months. Welcome to the arsenal of freedom. Better known as my bedroom. My parents are a bit too trusting.

DYLAN: Ah . . . they're clueless.

ERIC: Anyway, they don't come in here. I keep it clean. They stay out. Ok, here we've got a pretty awesome supply of crickets and pipe bombs. These are for the first ten minutes. Smoke 'em out. Scare 'em out. Then Molotov's if we get bored. Mix and match . . . Ok, let's clear up a few things with you people so we're not *(does the quote fingers)* "misunderstood." We are kind of a select case here. Don't think this will happen again.

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DYLAN: We're not like those kids in Arkansas. Idiots got caught.

ERIC: I hope you realize what we are implying: the most deaths in U.S. history.

DYLAN: The police, the parents, the world will be studying these videos.

ERIC: And don't blame the gun shows or Kmart for selling us shit—

DYLAN: Yeah, I don't want no laws on buying PVC pipes.

ERIC: And don't blame the school--

DYLAN: Yeah, the administration is doing a fine job as it is.

ERIC: *(cuts him off)* And don't blame my family; they're the best parents I have ever known. Do NOT blame anyone but me and *Dylan*!

DYLAN: This was our choice. Our decision.

ERIC: *(pushing Dylan out of the camera)* It's hatred that fuels this fire. See, even you are hating us right now. But I'll tell you something. You made me. You made US. *(flipping an obscene gesture toward the camera.)* Look at what you made. It's war. And in war there are victims. We . . . the victims. *(into the camera)* But this . . . all of this is the end of that. *(Close to the camera.)* I have so much rage inside me. Worst than a loaded gun because you just don't expect anything vicious from silence. Silence is deadly. The longer the silence, the more deadly. Shhhhhhh! *(turns camera off - LONG BEAT)*

DYLAN: Okay . . . So this is a bizarre question, but how do you really think it will end?

ERIC: Well, we're not getting out of there alive—not with all those cops out there. So, the best way to go is a shootout.

DYLAN: And then?

ERIC: Then what? We're dead. We're history . . . the greatest school shooting of all time.

DYLAN: We're going to be dead in two days. You're not scared?

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ERIC: Look, we have always been set on this. We put guns to our heads and count one, two three. That is the plan. It is what I will do. And I need you to do it. Like we planned.

DYLAN: *(Beat)* What if I don't?

ERIC: What did you say?

DYLAN: What if you shoot first, but I decide not to? What are you gonna do then?

ERIC: *(erupts)* Jesus Christ, what do you want, Dylan? You want to live this life? I'm done. Ok? I want one last memory. *(beat)* Go on. You can *kiss* ass until the day we throw our little caps in the air and sing "Columbine. Oh Columbine?" And Miss Valedictory gives her prize-winning speech about how wonderful it was at Columbine High School. . . I'm not going to sit there to listen to bullshit. No way. They don't deserve one more day past Tuesday. I want them to feel they almost got away with it. One last prom. One last yearbook picture . . .

DYLAN: You're not taking it, are you?

ERIC: What?

DYLAN: *(picks up a medicine bottle)* Your medicine. You're pretty *messed* up . . .

ERIC: What . . . you're worried cause I'm *angry*? We're gonna kick start a revolution. We'll be remembered forever. Like gods man, like gods . . .

DYLAN: Think of their faces . . .

ERIC: The ones on fire, screaming for help . . .

DYLAN: The world noticing our little high school, engulfed in flames.

ERIC: The power we'll have . . . Like gods, man, like gods. *(long beat)*

********* **SCENE CHANGE** *******

ACTOR 2: To this day, the parents of Eric Harris have never spoken publically about their son or his role in the shootings. Ten years after Columbine, Oprah Magazine

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published an essay written by Susan Klebold. *(ACTOR 1 hands ACTOR 1 a piece of paper.)*

ACTOR 1: *(reads with great emotion, the words of his mother)* My son Dylan . . . I failed to see that he needed help. *(beat)* I will never be able to explain or excuse what he did. For the rest of my life, I will be haunted by the horror and anguish he caused. I cannot look at a child without thinking about how my son's schoolmates spent the last moments of their lives. Dylan changed everything I believed about love. I think I believed that if I loved someone as deeply as I loved him, I would know if he were in trouble. My maternal instincts would keep him safe. But I didn't know, and my instincts weren't enough.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2014 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
2018 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier

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